

Two perspectives to assess the morality of a social practice: (126)

Interactional approach:

Focus on the individual's experience in the social practice

Assesses in terms of violations of duties not to harm the individual

Structural approach:

Focus on the collective's experience in the social practice

Assesses unjust distribution of power, knowledge, resources and their effects

The harm might not be significant to any single individual, but taken as a group, the harm is significant

Benn and Lazar's thesis:

While the interactional approach can discover moral wrongs, the criticism of automated influence is more compelling when one adopts a structural approach

In other words, Benn and Lazar will aim to show that automated influence leads to an unjust distribution of knowledge, resources, and/or power that promote invasions of privacy, exploitation, and manipulation

Automated Influence = (127)

“The use of Artificial Intelligence to collect, integrate and analyse people’s data, and to deliver targeted interventions based on this analysis, intended to shape their behaviour for exogenous or endogenous ends”

e.g., advertising, recommender systems, newsfeed and search algorithms

Targeting: (127)

- Matching people with products, services and content they may find appealing
- Tailoring the message to the individual based on their inferred susceptibility to that method of persuasion

⇒ Examples?

⇒ Do Benn and Lazar think targeting by automated influence is always morally wrong?

Exploitation = (135)

“One party to an ostensibly voluntary agreement intentionally takes advantage of a relevant and significant asymmetry of knowledge, power, or resources to offer the other party terms of exchange to which they agree but would never accept were they more symmetrically situated in that respect”

Exploitation: Interactional approach

Interactional approach's objection based on exploitation: (135)

Individual can claim that they were deceived: the automated influencer used "subterfuge to acquire data that was never intended to be shared"

- Requires showing that each individual "has a right to unilateral control over what they are exchanging" (their personal data)
- Disanalogy to using deception to obtain valuable artwork from an ignorant person in possession of the artwork

Exploitation: **Structural approach:** (136)

Resources: (136)

- an individual's data is worthless, but everybody's data taken together is valuable;
- individuals do not control the means of prediction (algorithms and calculations performed on the big data sets); all individuals can observe are the digital services

Knowledge: (136-137)

- Individuals (and their elected political representatives) do not have access to the algorithms, in order to determine how effective they are
- Individuals do not have a choice about research agendas

Power: (137)

- Individuals cannot directly observe the extent of the power, leaving no way for individuals or their representatives to legitimate this power;
- Tech companies decide how they want to use this power

Structural approach's objection based on exploitation: (138)

1. While the individual user's data is not worth much, the collection of many user's data is very valuable.
2. Users do not control the means of prediction.
3. But the focus is on control of the surplus of resources, knowledge, and power that the data collected generates.
4. Self-determining political communities have rights to set how that collective surplus is distributed.